

Digital self

The Internet is a liberating space for teens—they can control how they present themselves, as well as socialize and explore the wider world. But it's also vast, so it's essential teens learn to be aware of how they are perceived online.

Selfies

Self-portraits taken with a smartphone, more commonly called “selfies,” allow young people to have control over their online image. Through a selfie, teens can shape how they want to be seen, express their mood, and share important experiences with their online community, who can then comment on and “like” the selfie. Unfortunately, negative comments can be made online as easily as positive ones, which can influence a teen's self-esteem and become a real problem if the teen relies on selfies and other people's opinions to boost their self-worth.



▷ Selfie esteem

Selfies can be an effective way for teens to increase their confidence, test out new identities, and let their friends know what they're doing.

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ALERT!

Dangerous selfies

Selfies of people in precarious positions have become widespread on social media. Across the world, creating daredevil selfies is putting people's lives at risk. With teens more prone to risk-taking due to the changes that are taking place in their brains, it is important that they don't buy in to this dangerous trend, in which people have been injured and died. Instead, a person should be aware and ensure that they're safe before taking a selfie.

Think before posting

While posting a photo or comment on social media may feel like the most natural thing in the world, it is important to pause and think about what a post is saying or showing.

Although the comment or picture might only be intended for a specific person or group, the person writing the post needs to remember that it can actually be seen by a wider community of people. It will remain online beyond the moment, years into the future, as a part of their digital history.

▷ Consider the consequences

It's a good idea before posting to think about whether or not it would be embarrassing or awkward if a family member, teacher, or future employer saw the post.

